How to Ask Mom About Her Ordinary Week, and Compare Notes as a Family

One easy conversation with her, one with the family, and a way to write down what each person said.

You'd like to ask Mom how her week really goes, and you don't want it to sound like a meeting about her. It doesn't have to be a meeting at all. It can be a cup of coffee on an ordinary afternoon.

This guide is for two small conversations with one job between them: hear her account of her week, then put the family's notes beside it. Neither one is for deciding anything.

Who should be there

For the first conversation, Mom and one person she's easy with. That's all. It can happen over coffee or on the Thursday drive.

For the second, the people who see or help her: the sister who drives her to appointments, the brother who phones on Wednesday nights and, if Mom would like it, the neighbor who brings in the mail. Mom is welcome at this one too. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests including everyone who is part of the helping, which can mean a family friend or a neighbor, and notes that someone who can't travel can join by phone. [1]

Someone who can't join at all can send a few lines ahead. A text reply counts. Pick one person to write things down.

How to open

Start with an invitation, not an announcement. AARP's planning guide for families says not to try to anticipate what Mom will say: get the conversation started, expect it to take place over time and, most of all, listen. [2]

- “Mom, I realized I couldn't describe your week if someone asked me. Would you walk me through it?”
- “Nothing has happened, and this isn't about changing anything. I'd just like us all to have the same picture.”
- With the family: “Each of us sees a different part of Mom's week. Let's put the parts side by side, starting with what she told us.”
- Say what the conversation is for: one shared picture of how things work today. Say what it isn't for: changing where she lives or who does what.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom

1. What does an ordinary week look like for you?

2. Who do you see or hear from most weeks, and what do they do?

3. Is there anything about your week you'd like the rest of us to know?

Ask each other

1. Which part of Mom's week do you see, and when are you usually there or on the phone?

2. What do you do for her, and how often? Include the small things.

3. Who knows her daily routine best?

4. Where does your picture differ from hers, or from someone else's here?

5. What doesn't any of us know yet, and what should we get organized while there's time?

How to write down what was said

Keep Mom's own account separate from what the family has noticed. Where two people describe the same thing differently, write both and leave both. Where nobody knows, write “not yet known” instead of a guess.

WHAT WAS SAID OR SEEN	WHO SAID IT	WHICH PART OF THE WEEK	DESCRIBED DIFFERENTLY BY
“I'm up at six-thirty and I do the crossword before anything else.”	Mom	Mornings	
Drives her to her Thursday appointment, and they shop for groceries after.	Karen	Thursdays	David thought this was once a month

What not to decide yet

None of these is today's job. Today's job is a description, and a description with the differences left in is a good one.

- Whether Mom needs more help, or less.
- Whether anything about where she lives should change.
- Whose version of her week is the right one.

- Who should take on what.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes and send them round.
- Who will ask about each thing nobody knew.
- What the next conversation is, and who will start it.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a disagreement, decide anything, or tell you what a professional would say. It gets Mom's account and the family's notes onto one page, with the differences left on it.

Ready for the next step?

You've heard Mom's account of her week and put the family's notes beside it. The care interview takes that page through her situation area by area, including the parts no one thought to mention, and turns it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families